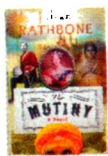


BAD COMPANY

History and fiction do not meld enough in this well-written novel to transport the reader to the days of the Raj



THE MUTINY
by JULIAN RATHBONE
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■ **By Tara Sahgal**

The armed uprisings against the British East India Company of 1857, 150 years ago, have been the subject of much controversy for decades. Given the number of literary works that reference the Partition saga, *The Mutiny* is a welcome read. It's fascinating to see Bahadur Shah Zafar, Rani of Jhansi and Tantya Tope in fiction, not to mention Lord and Lady Canning and Queen Victoria herself.

The story begins in 1853. Young Sophie has just arrived in India and is about to have every aspect of her existence totally rearranged in this strange, heathen land. Recently married to boring Tom Hardcastle, the assistant attorney general of the Meerut Contingent, Sophie's life and passions are tepid at best, embroiled in unfulfilled desires and frivolities. But not for long. To move from Dorset to Simla would be a challenge even today, but doing so at possibly the bloodiest point in British colonial history was just really bad timing. In the first chapter, Sophie and her friend Catherine Dixon gossip about the lineage of an 'apparently native lady', but less than a hundred pages into the book, it's 1857. The cow and pig fat has just hit the fan, Mangal Pandey has expressed his discontent and everyone is floundering around, knee-deep in gore.

Catherine and Sophie find themselves dodging bullets, bombs and butcher's knives, running for their lives with children in tow across the blood-bath developing in the north-central plain. You do tend to feel sorry for them

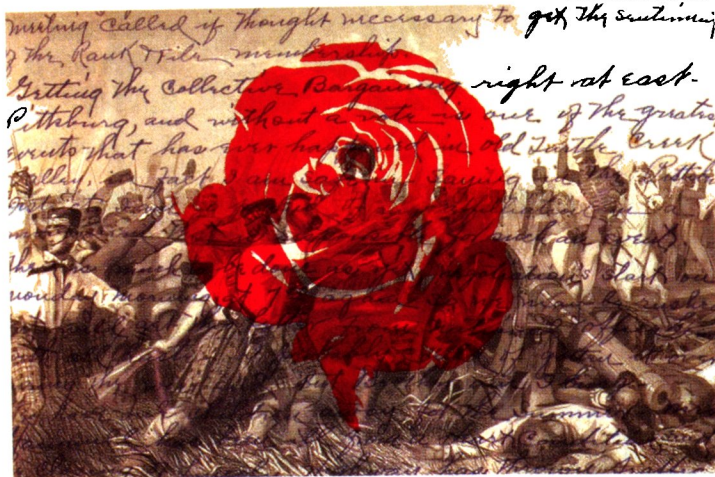
and the 'innocents' they represent, but the copious (though engaging) historical interludes and graphic descriptions of carnage on both sides dissipate any empathy that may be developing. It doesn't help that most characters, central and peripheral, fictional and historical, pop it with little or no ceremony and that the author himself seems to regard many of them as somewhat idiotic. Three lusty Indian women stand out as having an 'admirable' personality—Lavania, nursemaid to Sophie's children; beautiful Uma Blackstock, a half-Indian, half-English spy to the Rani of Jhansi; and the Rani herself.

In short, it's all well written (I suppose you would expect no less from a

clearer in his personal 'notes and reflections'. Here he talks of both sides being 'guilty of appalling atrocities' and states his view: what happened in 1857 was a 'mutiny', a 'revolt', perhaps even an 'uprising' in certain areas of the sub-continent, but was certainly no 'War of Independence' given how much of the Native Army remained either uninvolved or loyal to the British.

He also asks us to remember that “a state of anarchy existed in India in which rajas and princes fought each other, failed to maintain order and law, and indulged in massive conspicuous consumption that benefited no one but the moneylenders and tax farmers”. Indian Independence in 1947, he says,

was possible only because of the nation-state shaped by the Raj following the reforms post 1857, which included the creation of an influential native middle class from which Gandhi himself sprang. (No mention of Akbar's revenue minister Todar Mal's 'bandobast' centuries before the British arrived, which several historians claim was the reason why the British could 'unify' India in the first place.)



writer twice nominated for the Booker), but the history and fiction rarely meld together enough to be transporting, and in the end it's best read for its small, disconnected delights—portraits of real ranis and fictional fakirs, Vicky strolling in the royal gardens dreaming of dear, departed Albert, chatting with a hard-of-hearing gardener who may or may not have had a gay lover....

Rathbone has tried to present both sides of the story fairly, and the racial, religious and cultural bigotry of the Brits that sparked the whole slaughter in the first place is unflinchingly represented. Why he uses the potentially offensive 'mutiny' for the title rather than something more neutral becomes

While these notes plainly state that Britain benefited from the 'loot of empires', there is a definite suggestion, perhaps rightly so, that India is far better off today thanks to its colonisers than it would have been if left to its greedy rajas. After all, he says, after 1857, the British "only" took 1 per cent of the taxes collected in India for the British treasury, and pumped the rest back into schools, hospitals, railways and other infrastructure. Suddenly a delightfully clever construct of the novel—the revolt itself as a conspiracy involving the King of Delhi—begins to make sense, going to show that historical novels are really very political ones whose authors should probably let their characters do the talking! ■